

BOOK THREE OF THREE FREE GUIDES

HOW TO SPOT AI SCAMS AND PROTECT YOURSELF
ONLINE

Safe and Sound

The new tricks explained plainly, the family safe word, and a simple checklist to stick on the fridge. Reassuring, not frightening.

By Joseph Conlan
Clone Centre, Liverpool

CloneCentre

clonecentre.ai

A note from Joseph

Hello, Joseph Conlan here, from Clone Centre in Liverpool.

This is the third little book in our series, and in many ways the most important. Not because the internet is a frightening place, because it is not, and millions of people use it every day without any trouble at all. It is important because a few simple habits will protect you from almost every scam going, and most of them take about five minutes to learn.

Scammers have some new tools these days. Artificial intelligence lets them write more convincing emails, fake voices and fake videos more easily than before. That sounds alarming, but here is the reassuring truth: the defences have not changed. A scammer with the cleverest computer in the world still cannot beat a family safe word, a pause before you click, and a phone call to check.

Read this book once, fill in the checklist at the back, and stick it on the fridge. Then get on with enjoying everything the internet and AI have to offer.

Warm regards,

Joseph Conlan Founder, Clone Centre, Liverpool clonecentre.ai

Chapter 1: The new tricks, explained plainly

Scams are not new. A knock on the door from a charming rogue is as old as doors. What is new is that computers can now help scammers sound and look far more convincing than they used to. Here is what each trick actually is, in plain English, and the one habit that defeats it.

The voice that is not really them

Computers can now copy a person's voice from a short recording, sometimes from a video posted online. A scammer can then make that copied voice say anything, and ring you with it.

The typical story: your phone rings, and it sounds exactly like your son, your daughter or a grandchild, upset and urgent. They have been in an accident, or arrested, or stranded abroad, and they need money quickly. Please do not tell anyone.

The defence: hang up and ring the real person on the number you already have for them. If it was genuine, no harm done. If it was a scam, the trick collapses instantly. Real emergencies always survive a five minute check.

The video that is not really real

Fake videos, often called deepfakes, can now put a familiar face on screen saying things they never said. You might see what appears to be a well known newsreader or a famous face recommending an investment or a miracle cure.

The defence: be very slow to trust any video that asks for money or promises easy riches, whoever appears to be in it. Famous people do not message strangers about investments. If a video excites you into wanting to send money somewhere, that excitement is the warning sign.

The perfectly written email

Scam emails used to be easy to spot: bad spelling, odd grammar, a prince you had never heard of. AI now writes them cleanly and politely, and can make them look like your bank, HMRC, the TV licensing people or a delivery company. The goal is always the same: to make you click a link or hand over details.

The defence: never click links in unexpected emails or texts about money, deliveries or accounts. Instead, go to the company's website yourself, typing the address you already know,

or ring them on the number on your statement or card. If the message is real, it will still be there when you log in properly.

The new friend who is too good to be true

Romance scams happen on dating sites, social media and even ordinary chat groups. Someone friendly and attentive strikes up a conversation. They are often supposedly abroad, working on an oil rig or serving in the forces. Weeks of lovely messages build real trust. Then comes the crisis, and the request for money, gift cards or help with a fee.

AI makes this worse by letting one scammer keep up charming, flawless conversations with dozens of people at once.

The defence: never send money, gift cards or bank details to someone you have not met in person, however long you have been talking. A genuine new friend will never ask. And do tell a family member about online friendships; a second pair of eyes spots what the heart misses.

The grandchild emergency

This deserves its own mention because it is aimed so precisely at grandparents, and it works on the kindest people. A call or message arrives: "Gran, it is me." You say a name, and they take it. There has been an accident or an arrest. Money is needed for bail, a fine or a repair, and it must happen today, and please keep it secret from Mum and Dad.

Sometimes the voice is faked with AI. Sometimes it is just a good actor who lets you fill in the blanks.

The defence: two magic habits. First, ask a question only the real grandchild could answer, such as the name of their first pet or where you went for their last birthday. Second, use your family safe word, which we will set up in the next chapter. Then ring their parents or the grandchild's own number. Every genuine emergency can wait for one phone call.

The message that is almost right

Watch too for texts that are nearly right: a parcel that needs a small redelivery fee, a bank warning about a payment you never made, a prize from a draw you never entered. AI helps scammers personalise these at enormous scale.

The defence: the small fee and the urgent warning are both bait. Real delivery companies do not charge redelivery fees by text link. Real banks never ask you to move money to a "safe

account". Ever.

Chapter 2: How to know who you are really talking to

The family safe word

This is the single most useful idea in this book, and it takes ten minutes to arrange.

Choose one word or short phrase that only your family knows. Something memorable but not guessable from your social media: not a pet's name or a street you grew up on if those are posted online. "Purple teapot" is better than "Fluffy".

Agree on this rule with your children and grandchildren: any call, message or video that asks for money, codes or urgent help must include the safe word. No safe word, no action, and you ring the real person to check.

Write it down for family members, keep it off the internet entirely, and change it if you ever suspect it has slipped out. That is the whole system. It defeats voice fakes, video fakes and smooth talking strangers in one move.

Questions only they would know

Before any safe word is in place, or with people outside the family, ask something only the real person could answer. What did we have for Sunday lunch last week? What is the name of your old dog? Scammers bluff; family remember.

Ring back on the number you trust

If a call or message worries you, end it kindly and ring back using the number stored in your own phone, or the number on your bank card or statement. Never use a number given in the suspicious message itself. This one habit stops almost every impersonation scam, because the scammer cannot answer the real phone.

Take the urgency out

Every scam, without exception, depends on hurry. Today only. Do not tell anyone. Act now or lose the money, the prize, the chance. The moment you feel rushed by a message or a caller, treat the rush itself as the alarm bell. Genuine organisations give you time. Give yourself

permission to say: "I will think about it and ring you back." A legitimate caller will respect that. A scammer will push, and that tells you everything.

When money is involved, talk to a human first

Before sending money to anyone new, or buying anything suggested by a message or a video, mention it to one trusted person: a partner, a son or daughter, a friend. Scammers ask for secrecy precisely because one conversation unpicks the whole trick.

Chapter 3: What AI companies do with your data, in plain terms

A fair question, asked calmly: when you chat with an AI, where do your words go?

Your chats are stored. When you type into an AI chat, your messages are kept on the company's computers, much as your emails live on your email company's computers. This is how the service remembers your conversation.

They may be used to improve the service. Most AI companies say they may use conversations to train and improve their systems. Many let you switch this off in the settings, and the paid business versions usually do not train on your data at all. If you would like the training switched off, the settings page of your chosen service will have the option, and a family member can help you find it in a couple of minutes.

People may occasionally review samples. Companies sometimes have staff or contractors check small samples of conversations to make sure the system behaves properly. This is another reason for the golden rule below.

The golden rule of AI chats: never type in anything you would not want a stranger reading. That means no passwords, no bank or card numbers, no National Insurance number, no medical details tied to your name, and nothing about other people that they would not want shared. Ordinary questions, recipes, letters and curiosities are perfectly fine. Personal secrets and account numbers are not for any website, AI or otherwise.

Free means you are part of the exchange. When a service is free, the company is usually getting something too: your usage helps it improve its product, and it hopes you will one day pay for extras. This is a reasonable bargain as long as you know it is happening, and now you do.

You can delete your history. Every major AI chat lets you delete old conversations, and some let you use a temporary chat that is not saved. Look in the settings, or ask the AI itself: "How do I delete my chat history?" It will happily explain.

None of this needs to worry you. It simply means treating an AI chat like a helpful assistant in a shared office: wonderful for everyday help, not the place for your bank details.

Chapter 4: Ten golden rules to live by

- 1. Pause when rushed.** Urgency is the scammer's favourite tool. Nothing genuine collapses because you took an hour to think.
- 2. Ring back on your own number.** Check any worrying call by ringing the person or company on a number you already trust.
- 3. Use the safe word.** Agree it with your family this week. No word, no money, no exceptions.
- 4. Never click links about money or deliveries in unexpected messages.** Go to the website yourself instead.
- 5. Never move money to a "safe account".** Banks never, ever ask this. Anyone who does is a criminal.
- 6. Never share codes.** Any code texted to your phone is a key to your accounts. Banks and family will never ask you to read one out.
- 7. Keep personal details out of AI chats.** Questions are fine. Passwords, account numbers and National Insurance numbers are not.
- 8. Use different passwords for important accounts.** At the very least, your email and banking passwords should be unique and strong.
- 9. Accept updates.** When your phone or computer offers an update, let it. Updates close the holes scammers use.
- 10. Talk about it.** Mention odd messages and new online friends to someone you trust. Scammers rely on silence; sunlight finishes them.

If you do slip, and plenty of clever, careful people have, it is nothing to be ashamed of. Ring your bank straight away using the number on your card, tell a family member, and report it to Action Fraud on 0300 123 2040 or at [actionfraud.police.uk](https://www.actionfraud.police.uk). Acting quickly often gets money back.

Chapter 5: The fridge checklist

Fill this in, tick the boxes as you do them, and stick it on the fridge or by the phone. It is the whole of this book on one page.

☐ Our family safe word is agreed. (Write it here in pencil, or keep it written elsewhere and just tick.)

☐ I know how to ring back family on their real numbers, which are stored in my phone.

☐ I will never move money to a safe account, share a code from my phone, or click links in unexpected money or delivery messages.

☐ My email and banking passwords are different from each other, and written down somewhere safe at home.

☐ My phone and computer are set to update themselves.

☐ I keep passwords, card numbers and my National Insurance number out of AI chats and out of emails.

☐ I have told a family member where my important documents are kept.

☐ Before sending money to anyone new, I will talk it over with someone I trust first.

☐ My bank's real phone number is on the back of my card, and I know where my card is.

☐ Action Fraud: 0300 123 2040. If anything feels wrong, I can ring my bank first, then them.

About Clone Centre

Clone Centre is an independent AI consultancy based in Liverpool, founded by Joseph Conlan.

We help ordinary people and small organisations understand and use artificial intelligence, without the jargon and without the hard sell. That includes friendly training sessions, one to one help getting set up, and practical advice on staying safe online.

If you found this book useful, you may like the other two in the series: *AI in Plain English: A Friendly Guide for the Over 50s*, and *Everyday AI: 50 Simple Ways It Can Help Around the House and Beyond*.

You can find us, and get in touch, at **clonecentre.ai**.

Stay curious, stay careful, and enjoy it. The good things about this technology far outweigh the bad, once you know the handful of habits in this book.